Chapter Five

Eyeball to Eyeball: Blinking and Winking

> ‘stopping our ships by force … would be an act of war.’[1]
>
> (Anatoly Dobrynin)

> ‘There are just a host of circumstances we’ve thought of which we don’t believe we should try to give orders from here in relation to.’[2]
>
> (Robert McNamara)

> ‘We are eyeball to eyeball, and I think the other fellow just blinked.’[3]
>
> (Dean Rusk)

On the evening of Tuesday, 23 October 1962 the Reverend Billy Graham addressed 10,000 evangelical followers in Buenos Aires. His topic was ‘The End of the World.’[4] The following morning, the naval blockade of Cuba came into effect. SAC moved to DEFCON-2. There was widespread expectation that the Soviets would retaliate against West Berlin. The prospect of escalation to nuclear war looked alarmingly real. For the Reverend Billy Graham and his fellow evangelicals, embracing the end of the world meant keeping the faith. For the rest of humanity, the path to Armageddon was a terrifying and potentially imminent prospect.